"Keep the bags packed, who knows when needed"

Nerd Travel Blog

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Phi-Phi: Adventures of Colored Waters

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After hectic rounds of qualifying exams, me and my friends were looking for a place to relax and freshen up our minds when we heard about Koh Phi Phi islands in Thailand. It is an island roughly 46 kms ahead of Phuket and is famous among tourists for its mesmerizing sea view with small rock islands while offering various activities like snorkelling, deep sea diving, kayaking among others. Impressed by the natural views (It amuses us more because we live in Singapore, which as described perfectly by one of our friends is a concrete jungle) and refreshing experience that it has to offer we planned a two-days trip to Phi Phi while visiting Phuket for two days towards the start and end of the journey.

Wat Chalong Temple, Phuket

Day-1

So, we booked a cheap AirAsia flight from Singapore to Phuket and we were set for the journey. So we began our trip from T4 terminal of Changi airport, Singapore, which offers an amazing experience in itself when it comes to food, shopping, exotic washrooms (😜) and fascinating architectural pieces. So, after the boring process of check-in, immigration and security we began our journey by having lunch at an Indian store in the international food court (Only because the three of us are vegetarian 😉). There are many other food stores available serving cuisines of different nationalities which can be given a shot. After lunch we experimented with the new DSLR of our friend DS to capture some of the architectural beauties with us beside them. Finally we boarded the flight and landed at the Phuket International Airport. We decided to go to one of the famous attractions of Phuket, Wat Chalong temple as it was on our way to our stay Na Siam Guesthouse, Old Phuket town. We took a Grab[1] from the airport to reach the destination which was a hassle as Grabs are not allowed in the airport area, so we walked in the sun and humidity, sweating all along in search of Grab pick up point, which was somehow an assumed place. After all the hassle, we managed to get into Grab and reached Wat Chalong Temple after about 50-55 minutes of journey. The temple was mesmerizing and peaceful with its detailed architectural richness and Buddha statues.

After about an hour of roaming around, taking pictures with awesome temple we decided to finally go to the guesthouse. Na Siam guesthouse was an economical stay option and as we went around October, it was off season and we were among the very few people staying there. The guesthouse has an awesome location, situated right in the centre of Phuket Old town, surrounded with cute lire of Phuket Old town, surrounded with cute little souvenir shops with interesting items made up of bamboo, wood etc. The area also had many good cafes cum shops with great ambience and awesome food. We went to one such café named Eleven Co & in for dinner. We had Fried Pad Thai and Coconut Thai Tea which was among one of the best we have had. We also tried Phuket beer which was smooth and tasted different. After the awesome dinner, we roamed around in the Old Phuket town looking around at the street arts, paintings, old small colourful buildings and experimenting again with the camera on the streets of town. Although almost all the shops were closed around 9-9:30 pm, maybe because of the off season. After all the photography adventures, we ended our day by chilling out and chatting at our guesthouse. Meanwhile the guesthouse manager managed to get us ferry tickets to and fro from PhiPhi (700 baht/person)[2] for next morning at a reasonable rate included with two and fro conveyance fee to Rassada Pier.

Day-2

After spending the night in the beautiful old town of Phuket, we began our journey towards the famous Koh Phi Phi island. We had pickup service from our guest house to Rassada Pier included in our ferry tickets which dropped us to the desired ferry pickup point. We then boarded the very first ferry to Koh Phi Phi island starting at 8:30 am. The ferry was good enough for a 2.5 hours journey with Tom Jerry show being broadcasted which made my judgement biased towards the service, as it is one of my favorites from childhood 😜. Despite of the magnificent scenic beauty that could be seen from the ferry, we weren't able to enjoy it much in the beginning. We sorted out that the reason was us being hungry which we later solved out. After having breakfast, we had a good 2 hours ride standing at the deck and looking around the speedboats, small islands, infinite seas and the view of Phuket city being left behind us. With this view around, and our photographer DS, me and my friend PP had a good time discussing life. DS managed to get some awesome pics of the view as well as us with iconic scenery. The cool breeze totally made us neglect the sun that shined upon us as we enjoyed the view. After 2 hours of photography, discussions, seeing views we finally reached Tonsai Pier ferry terminal Phi Phi around 11:00 am. We then headed towards our resort "Phi Phi Chukit resort" with the help of google maps which misguided us and made us walk about 1.3 kms while our destination was just 500 m away from the Tonsai Pier ferry terminal. But yeah during the walk we managed to have a glimpse of the narrow streets of the small island with beautiful buildings, all decorated with colourful souvenir shops and food stalls <3.

Narrow streets of Phi Phi

Meanwhile we also got to see many beautiful cats as my friends would say, but scary in my opinion because of their wicked evil eyes. After checking in at the resort, we had lunch at the resort restaurant located by the sea, with excellent view and tasty food. We had pizza and drinks. After lunch we headed to Blue view divers office as they were up for taking us to the island hopping trip. The office lady introduced us to our guide who was a British lady named Natalie who was supposed to head our island hopping and snorkelling trip. We began our island hopping journey with ride in the long-tail boat wherein we were briefed about our life jackets, fins and breathing masks before we actually jumped into the sea to snorkel.

Our long tail boat at twilight

We had a glimpse of the Monkey beach and Viking caves on our way. Then we reached our first snorkelling location near the Viking caves. My friends PP and DS knew swimming to some extent, but I (Juhi) was the one with zero swimming experience. Despite that I somehow jumped into the sea and started floating. Although after a while I started panicking as I was floating with head upwards, wherein PP came to rescue and pacified me, after which I was a bit relaxed. After that the instructor told me to hold a side of the floating life jacket and as she moved forward, I moved, basically getting movement with help of life jacket. We had an amazing time watching fishes, turtles, coral reefs, group of beautiful colourful fishes and even a baby shark, we also managed to find NEMO 😜 and baby Sharks. Similar was the second snorkelling experience near the famous Maya Bay, and this time I didn't panic at all!! (I was brave 😎😎). We enjoyed the beautiful sunset as the long tail boat moved towards our third snorkelling spot with shiny Planktons that illuminate in dark. The third snorkelling experience was full of mixed emotions. On one hand I was very happy seeing the luminescent Planktons, while on the other hand I was panicking because the water was shallow, it was dark, and I felt uncomfortable because of my breathing mask. Again this time PP came to rescue, he helped me but his legs got stung by see urchins during the process which was not deadly but hurts a lot because of saline water. After about 4 hours of snorkelling, floating, panicking, feeling chilly due to the breeze we returned to our resort. At the end we can confidently say that even a non-swimmer can snorkel with help of instructor and friends and enjoy the beautiful views and creatures that the sea has to offer.

The world under the sea

Also, there were options to rent a kayak and explore the nearby areas of the island. After freshening up, we went to dinner around 8:30-9:00 pm and walking along the streets we found Dow restaurant with lots and lots of crowd. The same restaurant was also suggested by our guide Natalie for its good and famous food. The restaurant served some amazing shakes and extremely tasty food, although vegetarian. They also have a non-vegetarian outlet just in front of the veg one. The place was full of books making it a place where one can relax and read with peace. After eating beyond our limits, we didn't have the courage to explore any further, so we decided to go back to resort and doze off, thereby ending our Day 2 of the trip.

Day 2: Snorkelling!

Day-3

Day 3 of our trip started with the pool training for scuba diving arranged by Blue view divers' and conducted by their expert divers Natalie and Mathiya (Not good with Italian names 😀). My friends were well trained by them while I was trying to capture the amazing view of the infinite sea and mountains.

Scuba Diving School!

Later after the training we went on to grab quick lunch and get back to our longboat for diving. There were two diving locations, one near the famous Maya Bay and other near Palong wall. The scenic views near both the spots were mesmerizing. The long boat then took us to Pileh Lagoon for having lunch break and the view was breath-taking. The lagoon is surrounded by rock mountains on all sides with little doorway spaces and filled with calm green water. The waves are so calm here, feels like one is far far away from the wild sea and in the lap of calm, beautiful green nature (Green water as well as plants). One can just sit there for hours and relax, away from the noises and lights of cities. People who are good swimmers can also dive in the water and snorkel or just swim around.

Scenic Pileh Lagoon

Later on, we headed towards the second diving spot near the Palong wall. After my friends headed for their second diving experience, the captain took the long boat away from the wall and rested the boat somewhere in the middle of sea, far far away from the commercial speed boats and cruises. There was no other boat or humans in sight, only the blue infinite sea, the sky with patches of moving clouds and some rock mountains. The

only sound I could hear of was the slow motion of water and air. I just sat and looked at the horizon far far away for about 20-25 minutes and it felt like a long time. This was the best part of the trip for me, when I was surrounded by nature without any disturbance from humans, none at all. I found solace in that place. Those 45 minutes were the best, it was for the first time that I had the opportunity to spend time alone in the lap of nature, in complete isolation :D. I was just thoughtless for a while, very calm, just looking around the beauty and enjoying it. I loved it <3. I am thankful to our captain for this experience, lovely person.

Tranquility in the middle of the sea!

Later on, my friends were back from their second diving, and we headed towards Phi Phi, tired but satisfied and happy from our experiences, also tanned badly 😜. After reaching we just freshened up and headed to explore the island further. The first thing we did was to get a thai massage and feel relaxed. Thereafter we just explored the colourful street market and looked out for souvenirs for our family and friends. The market is full of attractive, colourful items made up of coconut shell, bamboo, wood or jute. After our share of shopping we headed for dinner at the same Dow's restaurant and went back to room as we were completely drained out. Thus, ending our trip at Phi Phi.

Day-4

Streets of Phuket

We took the 11:00 am ferry to Phuket from Tonsai Pier after breakfast. The ferry dropped us at Rassada Pier around 2:00 pm, after which we just headed to Phuket old city for lunch and more shopping. We shopped more in the streets of Phuket and also took some great photos of the colourful old town streets. After exhausting ourselves with all these activities, we decided to head to Airport, thereby ending our amazing, memorable trip.

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* Author knows nothing.

Authors would like to thank *Apoorva Goel* for tolerating us and helping in "Economy of Scale" during trip.

All sections written in first person are from first author's point of view.

[1] Cab-hailing service in south-east asia

[2] Thai Currency